

AMERICAN PERCUSSION-CAP REVOLVERS

Revolving pistols were made less cumbersome by the percussion cap (see pp.80–81), which improved the single-action revolver (in which the hammer is cocked manually) that had become a reality by the end of the 17th century. These revolvers were loaded with powder and projectile (bullet or ball) from the muzzle of each chamber with the help of a device called a compound rammer. Samuel Colt patented his revolver in the UK in 1835 and in the US in 1836. His revolver, and its later copies, mostly used an open-frame construction, while some other makers favored a solid frame, with a top strap of metal above the cylinder.

► COLT MODEL 1849 POCKET REVOLVER

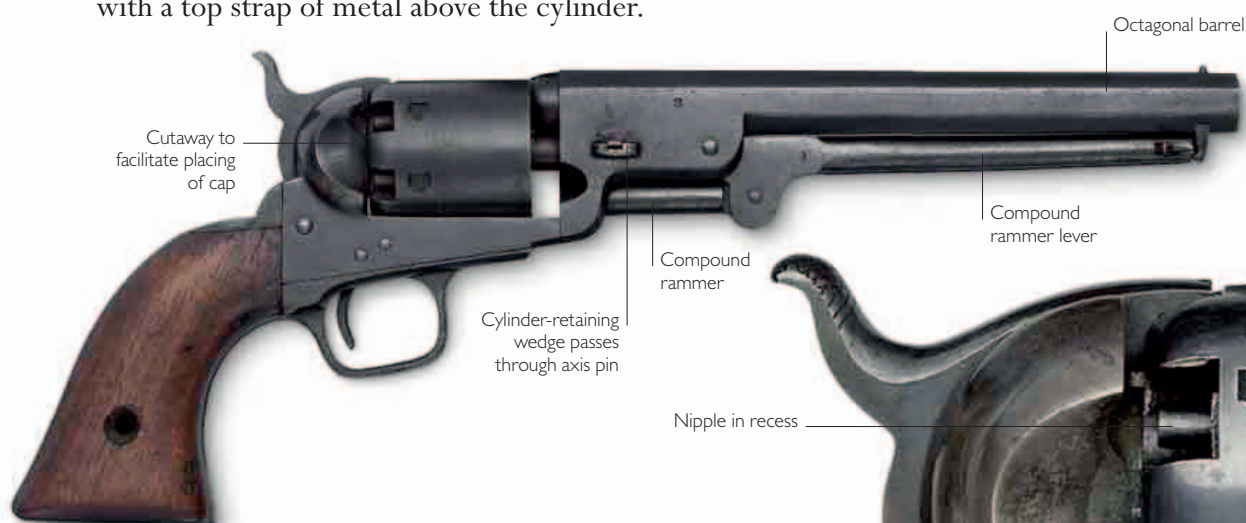
Date 1849

Origin US

Barrel 4in (10.2cm)

Caliber .31in (7.87mm)

A revised version of his 1848 revolver, the Baby Dragoon, Samuel Colt's 1849 single-action Pocket revolver had a standard compound rammer, choice of three barrel lengths, and a five- or six-shot cylinder.



▲ COLT MODEL 1851 NAVY REVOLVER

Date 1851

Origin England

Barrel 7½in (19cm)

Caliber .36in (9.14mm)

At the Great Exhibition of 1851 in London, Samuel Colt introduced the Navy Model, a single-action, open-frame light revolver in .36 in (9.14mm) rather than .44in (11.17mm) caliber. After the display, he obtained an order from the British government. This is one of the revolvers produced at his company's London factory.

Cylinder-retaining wedge passes through axis pin

Compound rammer

Compound rammer lever

Slot for cylinder-locking bolt

Nipple in recess

Cylinder axis pin

Brass back strap

Engraved cylinder

Trigger

Brass trigger guard

Hammer spur

Side-mounted hammer

Cylinder-locking screw

Walnut grips

► COLT MODEL 1855 POCKET REVOLVER

Date 1855

Origin US

Barrel 3½in (8.9cm)

Caliber .28in (7.1mm)

Elisha Root, the Colt Works Superintendent, designed the 1855 Pocket revolver. This single-action revolver had a solid-frame design in which the cylinder was held in a rectangular frame made by the top and bottom straps, the standing breech end, and the part of the frame forming the rear of the barrel.

